

The Meltdown Playbook

**The Exact Words to Calm Tantrums and Big
Feelings**

Emotional Regulation Scripts for Parents of Kids 2 to 7

A Calm Words Parenting Guide · Book 1

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Important note. This book offers general educational information about parenting and children's emotions. It is not medical, psychological or professional advice, and it does not replace care from your child's pediatrician or a licensed professional. If your child's behavior worries you, if meltdowns are very frequent, very long or getting worse, if anyone is getting hurt, or if your child is losing skills they once had, please talk to your pediatrician.

The families and children described in this book are illustrative composites, not real people. Any resemblance to a specific family is coincidental.

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Start Here: You're Not a Bad Parent. You Just Need the Words.

It's 5:40 on a Tuesday. Dinner is half made. Your four-year-old wanted to press the elevator button, and his sister pressed it first. Now he is face-down on the kitchen floor, screaming like the world has ended.

You know you're supposed to stay calm. You've read the posts. You've saved the videos. But right now, in this moment, your mind is blank. So you say the thing you swore you'd never say. Or you raise your voice. Or you hand him your phone just to make it stop.

Later, after bedtime, you replay it and feel awful.

If that sounds like your house, I want you to hear this first: **you are not a bad parent**. You are a tired parent who was never given the words. That's a very different problem, and it's one we can fix.

Why you freeze in the moment

Here's something most parenting advice skips. When your child melts down, your own stress rises too. Your heart speeds up. Your patience drains. And the part of your brain that is good at finding gentle, clever words is exactly the part that gets harder to reach when you're stressed.

That's why "just stay calm and connect" doesn't help much at 5:40 pm. You can't invent calm words while you're flooded. You can only *remember* them.

So this book gives you words to remember. Short, simple scripts you can learn when life is quiet and pull out when it isn't.

What this book is

This is a playbook, not a textbook. It's built to be used, not just read.

- **Part 1 (Chapters 1 to 3)** gives you the foundation: how to calm yourself first, what's really going on inside your child during a meltdown, and a simple four-step formula that works for almost any hard moment. Read this part first. It takes about 20 minutes, and you can start using it tonight.
- **Part 2 (Chapters 4 to 10)** is the playbook itself: 30 real moments, from the checkout-lane candy standoff to "I hate you!", each with the exact words to say. Don't read it cover to cover. Find your moment and use it.
- **Part 3 (Chapters 11 to 13)** helps you have fewer meltdowns in the first place. You'll teach feelings while everyone is calm, learn how to repair things after you lose your temper, and follow a simple 30-day plan.

Every moment in Part 2 follows the same layout, so once you've used one, you know how to use them all. The words to say are always in **bold**. If you only have ten seconds, read the bold line and go.

What this book is not

This book is for everyday meltdowns in children aged about 2 to 7. It is not therapy, and it can't diagnose anything. Some children need more help than any book can give, and that is nobody's fault. Chapter 10 explains the signs that it's time to talk to your pediatrician.

It also isn't a promise that your child will never melt down again. Meltdowns are a normal part of growing up. The goal is shorter

storms, calmer adults, and a child who slowly learns to handle big feelings, with you right beside them.

A few notes before you start

The scripts are starting points. Change the words so they sound like you. A script you actually say beats a perfect one you forget.

Some scripts won't work the first time. That's normal. Children test new responses. Use the same words for a week before you decide whether they help.

The families in this book are illustrative. Maya, Leo and the other children you'll meet are composites, built from the kinds of moments almost every family knows. They are not real people.

You don't have to be perfect. You will still lose your temper sometimes. Every parent does. Chapter 12 shows you how to repair those moments, and repair turns out to be one of the best things you can teach your child.

Your first step

Before you turn the page, think about the last week at home. Which moment happened most? Leaving somewhere fun? Screens off? Bedtime? Hitting a sibling?

Find it in the **Find Your Moment** list at the front of this book and circle it, fold the page corner, or add a bookmark. That's the moment we'll work on first.

Then read Chapter 1. It's short, and it will give you something to try before tomorrow's first meltdown.

PART 1

Before You Say a Word

Read this part tonight. It takes about 20 minutes, and you can use it tomorrow.

CHAPTER 1

Calm Is Contagious, So Catch It First

Maya is three. Her toast was cut into rectangles, and she wanted triangles. Now the toast is on the floor and Maya is screaming.

Her dad feels the heat rise in his chest. “Maya. MAYA. Stop it. It’s just toast!” His voice gets louder. Maya’s gets louder too. Within a minute they are both yelling, and nobody has eaten breakfast.

Rewind the scene. This time, before he says a word, Maya’s dad takes one slow breath out. He crouches down. He lowers his voice. “You wanted triangles. I’m right here.” Maya still cries, but the crying starts to slow down instead of speeding up.

Same toast. Same child. Same dad. The difference was what happened in his body in the first few seconds.

Your child borrows your calm

Young children can’t calm themselves down yet. The brain skills they need for that are still being built, and they will keep developing for years (Chapter 2 explains this).

Until those skills are ready, children rely on the adults around them. Researchers who study self-regulation call this **co-regulation**: a caring adult helps a child calm down, again and again, and over time the child learns to do it on their own.¹

1. Murray, Rosanbalm, Christopoulos and Hamoudi, *Self-Regulation and Toxic Stress: Foundations for Understanding Self-Regulation from an Applied Developmental Perspective*, OPRE Report 2015-21, Administration for Children and Families (2015).

In plain words, **your child borrows your nervous system**. When you get louder, faster and tenser, your child's storm tends to grow. When you get slower, lower and softer, you give them something steady to hold on to.

This is good news. It means the most powerful tool you have in a meltdown isn't a clever sentence. It's your own calm. And calm is a skill you can practice.

The 60-Second Reset

This is what you do in the first minute of a meltdown, *before* you try to fix anything. It has four steps. You can do all four while your child is still screaming.

1. Plant your feet. Stop moving. Feel both feet on the floor. If you can, crouch down so you're closer to your child's height. This tells your own body: *I'm not running, and I'm not attacking*.

2. Breathe out slowly. Take one breath in, then let it out slowly, longer than the breath in. Count to five as you breathe out if that helps. Do it two or three times. Focus on the long breath out.

3. Soften your face. Unclench your jaw. Relax your forehead. Let your shoulders drop. Your child reads your face faster than your words, and a soft face says *you're safe with me*.

4. Drop your voice. When you speak, speak lower and slower than you want to. If your child is loud, go quiet. A quiet voice is hard to argue with.

That's the whole reset. It takes about a minute, and nobody else needs to notice you're doing it.

"But I don't have 60 seconds!"

Sometimes you don't. If your child is about to run into the street or hit the baby, **safety comes first**. Move, block, pick them up. Then do the reset once everyone is safe.

In every other meltdown, you almost always have one minute. The toast will wait. The screen can stay on for sixty more seconds. The storm is not an emergency, even when it sounds like one.

The 3-Line Meltdown Script

Once you've done the reset, you need something to say. Most parents grab whatever comes out first: "Stop crying." "Calm down." "You're being ridiculous." Those words are understandable, but they tend to add fuel.

Here is what to say instead. Learn these three lines and you'll have something useful to say in almost any meltdown:

"I see you're ____." "I'm right here." "I won't let you ____."

Let's look at each line.

Line 1: "I see you're ____." Name what you see. *"I see you're really mad." "I see you're so disappointed." "I see you wanted triangles."* You aren't agreeing that the toast is a tragedy. You're showing your child that you noticed what's happening inside them.

Line 2: "I'm right here." Tell them they're not alone. A child in a meltdown feels out of control, and that is scary. This line says *the adult is still in charge, and the adult is staying*.

Line 3: "I won't let you ____." Hold the limit, calmly. *"I won't let you throw food." "I won't let you hit." "I won't let you run into the parking lot."* Notice that it's about what **you** will do, not an order your child has to follow. That's why it works even when they're too upset to listen.

You don't always need line 3. If your child is crying but not doing anything unsafe or off-limits, lines 1 and 2 are often enough.

The script in action

Here's how it sounds in a few common moments.

Leaving the playground: “I see you’re sad we have to go. I’m right here. I won’t let you run away from me in the parking lot.”

Screens off: “I see you’re really mad the show ended. I’m right here. I won’t let you throw the remote.”

A sibling took a toy: “I see you’re so frustrated. I’m right here. I won’t let you hit your brother.”

Then stop talking. This is the hardest part. After the three lines, **stay close and stay quiet**. A flood of extra words is more for the adult than the child. Let your calm do the work.

What happens next

The storm usually doesn’t stop the moment you say the script. That’s okay. You aren’t trying to switch the feelings off. You’re trying to help your child move through them faster, with you beside them.

Sometimes it looks like this:

- The screaming continues, but it slowly gets quieter.
- Your child crawls into your lap, or lets you rub their back.
- They look at you and start talking, even if it’s to complain.

Any of those means the script is working. When your child is calm enough to talk, *then* you can problem-solve, talk about what happened, or move on with your day. Chapter 3 shows you exactly how.

Why your child might push back

The first few times you use the reset and the script, your child may seem to melt down *harder*. Some children test a new response to see if it’s real. Others are surprised that the grown-up didn’t yell, and they aren’t sure what to do with that.

Keep going. Use the same words for at least a week. Staying consistent is what helps a new pattern settle in.

When you're the one about to lose it

Some days, you'll feel your own storm rising and the reset won't feel like enough. That's human. Here are two extra moves for those days:

Name it out loud. *"I'm feeling really frustrated right now. I'm going to take a big breath."* Then do it. You're calming yourself and showing your child how it's done.

Take a safe pause. If your child is safe, it's okay to step a few feet away. *"I need a minute to calm my body. I'll be right here."* Stay where your child can see you. A short pause is much better than an explosion.

If you do explode, don't panic. Chapter 12 shows you how to repair it, and repair is one of the most useful things your child can learn from you.

Your 5-Minute Action

1. **Practice the 60-Second Reset twice today, while things are calm.** Standing at the sink, waiting for the kettle, sitting in the car. Practicing when it's easy makes it automatic when it's hard.
2. **Write the 3-Line Meltdown Script somewhere you'll see it.** A sticky note on the fridge, the lock screen of your phone, or the tear-out card below.
3. **Use the script at the next meltdown.** Just once. Notice what happens, without judging yourself.

That's it. You now have a plan for the first minute of any meltdown.

POCKET CARD: THE 3-LINE MELTDOWN SCRIPT

First: Feet. Breathe out. Soft face. Low voice.

“I see you’re ____.”

“I’m right here.”

“I won’t let you ____.”

Then: Stay close. Stay quiet.

CHAPTER 2

Your Child Isn't Giving You a Hard Time. They're Having One.

Leo is five. He asked for a snack before dinner, and his mom said no. Leo stomped his feet, yelled “You’re so mean!”, and slammed his bedroom door.

His mom stood in the hallway thinking, *He knows better. He’s doing this on purpose. He’s trying to get to me.*

It’s an easy thought to have. It’s also, most of the time, not quite true.

Leo does know the rule about snacks. What he doesn’t have yet is a brain that can hold back a wave of disappointment when he’s hungry, tired and five years old. He isn’t giving his mom a hard time. He’s *having* one.

That shift, from “he’s doing this to me” to “he’s having a hard time,” changes how you respond. And it’s backed by what we know about how children’s brains grow.

Self-control is still under construction

Children aren’t born with self-control. They’re born with the *potential* to build it. The skills that let us pause before we act, hold our temper, and switch plans without falling apart grow slowly through childhood. Ages 3 to 5 are a period of especially fast growth, and these skills keep developing through the teenage years and into early adulthood.²

Think about what that means. Your four-year-old is being asked to handle disappointment with a brain that won't be fully finished for another twenty years. Some days, it simply isn't up to the job.

That's not an excuse for hitting or throwing. Limits still matter, and this book will help you hold them. But it explains *why* meltdowns happen, and why lectures during a meltdown rarely work.

The upstairs brain and the downstairs brain

A helpful way to picture this comes from psychiatrist Dan Siegel and parenting expert Tina Payne Bryson.³ They describe the brain as a house with two floors.

The downstairs brain handles big feelings and quick reactions: fear, anger, the urge to fight or run. It's fully working from birth, and it acts fast.

The upstairs brain handles thinking things through: planning, making good choices, seeing another person's side, calming down. It's still being built all through childhood.

In a meltdown, the downstairs brain takes over. The upstairs brain, the part that could listen to your reasons, is hard for your child to reach in that moment.

This is why reasoning with a screaming three-year-old goes nowhere. *"If you'd just let me explain, you'd see that the blue cup is in the dishwasher..."* The part of the brain that could follow that sentence isn't taking calls right now.

So the order matters:

1. **First, help the downstairs brain feel safe.** That's your calm (Chapter 1) and simple, short words.
2. **Then, once your child is calmer, talk to the upstairs brain.** That's when you can explain, problem-solve and teach.

2. Center on the Developing Child at Harvard University, *InBrief: Executive Function*, developingchild.harvard.edu.

3. Daniel J. Siegel and Tina Payne Bryson, *The Whole-Brain Child* (Delacorte Press, 2011).

Almost every script in this book follows that order.

Tantrums are normal (really)

If your toddler melts down every day, it can feel like something is wrong. Usually, nothing is.

The American Academy of Pediatrics describes tantrums as a normal part of development. They often start somewhere between 12 and 18 months, tend to be at their worst between ages 2 and 3, and ease as children learn to use words to say what they want and need.⁴

That last part is important. A lot of meltdowns are really a communication problem. Your child has a big feeling and not enough words to handle it. As their words grow, and as you give them more words to use (Chapter 11), the storms usually get shorter and less frequent.

This doesn't mean every meltdown is fine, or that you should just wait it out. Chapter 10 lists the signs that it's worth talking to your pediatrician. But for most families, daily tantrums in a two-year-old are a sign of normal growth, not a sign of bad parenting.

Tantrum or meltdown? Two different moments

People use these words in lots of ways. In this book, we use them to mean two different kinds of moments, because they need different responses.

A tantrum is about getting something. Your child wants the cookie, the toy or five more minutes, and they're protesting loudly to get it. They still have some control. You might notice them checking to see if you're watching. The feeling is real, but part of the upstairs brain is still switched on.

4. American Academy of Pediatrics, "Top Tips for Surviving Tantrums," [HealthyChildren.org](https://www.healthychildren.org).

What helps: stay calm, stay kind, and **hold the limit**. Don't give in to end the noise. If screaming gets the cookie, your child learns that screaming works.

A meltdown is about being overwhelmed. Your child is past the point of wanting something. They're flooded. Too tired, too hungry, too much noise, too many feelings at once. They may not even remember what started it. They're not checking whether you're watching. They've lost control.

What helps: **comfort and safety first**. Lower the noise, get close, say less. This is not the moment to teach a lesson. It's the moment to help their body settle.

In real life, the two can blur. A tantrum can tip into a meltdown if it goes on long enough. If you're not sure which one you're seeing, start with calm and comfort. You can always hold a limit once your child is calmer, and you'll rarely go wrong by leading with safety.

The usual suspects: what sets off a storm

Meltdowns can seem to come out of nowhere. But if you look closely, the same few triggers show up again and again. Here's a simple way to remember the most common ones.

H is for Hungry. A drop in energy makes everything harder. Many "late afternoon meltdowns" are really "it's been four hours since lunch" meltdowns.

A is for Angry. Something already went wrong today: a fight at daycare, a broken toy, a sibling who got the front seat. The feeling didn't go away. It waited.

L is for Lonely. Children who feel disconnected, maybe because a parent has been busy, or a new baby has arrived, often act out to get close to you, even if that closeness comes as a fight.

T is for Tired. Late nights, skipped naps and big days show up as short tempers.

Add one more: **transitions**. Moving from one activity to another is hard for young children, especially when they're leaving something fun. Leaving the park, turning off the TV, getting in the car, going to bed. A lot of the scripts in Part 2 are about transitions for exactly this reason.

When you spot a trigger, you have two kinds of help available.

- **In the moment**, it tells you what your child needs. A hungry child needs a snack more than a lecture. A lonely child needs you close.
- **Before the moment**, it helps you prevent the next storm. A snack in your bag before the store. A warning before screen time ends. An earlier bedtime after a big day.

What your child needs from you in a meltdown

Putting all of this together, here's what a child in a storm really needs. Not a perfect parent. Just these three things:

Safety. Nobody gets hurt, and nothing gets broken that matters. You'll hold that limit calmly (the "I won't let you" line from Chapter 1).

Connection. Someone who stays close and stays kind, even when they're not being their best self. That's you, lending them your calm.

Time. The downstairs brain needs a few minutes to settle before the upstairs brain can come back online. Waiting is part of the job, not a failure.

Teaching comes later. When your child is calm again, you can talk about what happened, practice a better way to handle it, and make a plan for next time. Chapter 3 shows you how to do all of that in four simple sentences.

A quick reality check

If your child melts down more than other children seem to, remember that you usually see other families at their best moments, not their worst. Every child has a different temperament. Some feel things more strongly and need more help calming down. That isn't a flaw in them or in you.

It does mean some children need more practice, and some parents need more patience. This book is built for exactly that.

Your 5-Minute Action

Track three meltdowns this week. You don't need to fix anything yet. Just notice. For each meltdown, write down:

- **When** it happened (time of day)
- **What** set it off
- **Which** HALT trigger might have been in play: Hungry, Angry, Lonely, Tired, or a transition
- **What** helped, even a little

After three meltdowns, look for a pattern. Most parents find one: the same time of day, the same kind of transition, the same missing snack. That pattern is your first target.

MELTDOWN TRACKER

Meltdown 1

Day and time: _____

What set it off: _____

Hungry / Angry / Lonely / Tired / Transition (circle)

What helped: _____

Meltdown 2

Day and time: _____

What set it off: _____

Hungry / Angry / Lonely / Tired / Transition (circle)

What helped: _____

Meltdown 3

Day and time: _____

What set it off: _____

Hungry / Angry / Lonely / Tired / Transition (circle)

What helped: _____

The pattern I notice: _____

CHAPTER 3

Four Sentences That Calm Almost Any Storm

Ava is six. Her best friend is going home after a playdate, and Ava is not ready. She grabs the friend's backpack and won't let go. "You can't leave! It's not fair!"

Her mom has two voices in her head. One says, *Be firm. She can't grab things.* The other says, *Be kind. She's just sad.* Most parents feel pulled between those two voices all the time, and they end up flipping between them. Too strict, then too soft, then strict again.

Here's the secret: **you don't have to choose.** The best responses are kind *and* firm at the same time. This chapter gives you a simple formula that does both, in four sentences.

The Calm Words Formula

The 3-Line Meltdown Script from Chapter 1 is your emergency tool. It's what you say when your mind is blank. The **Calm Words Formula** is the full version. Once you know it, you can build your own script for any situation, including ones this book never mentions.

It has four steps:

1. **Connect:** show your child you understand what they wanted.
2. **Name it:** put a word to the feeling.
3. **Hold the limit:** say calmly what will and won't happen.
4. **Offer a way out:** give them something they *can* do.

Here's Ava's mom using all four:

Connect: "You really wanted Zoe to stay longer." **Name it:** "You're so sad the playdate is over." **Hold the limit:** "I won't let you take her backpack. Zoe is going home now." **Offer a way out:** "Do you want to walk her to the door, or wave from the window?"

Four sentences. Kind the whole way through, and the backpack still goes home with Zoe.

Let's look at why each step matters.

Step 1: Connect

Connecting means showing your child that you understand what they *wanted*, before you say anything about what they did.

"You really wanted Zoe to stay longer." "You wanted to keep playing." "You were hoping for the red one."

You're not agreeing that they should get it. You're just showing that you see the world from where they're standing. For a child in a storm, feeling understood is often the first thing that helps their body relax.

Tip: start with "You wanted..." or "You were hoping..." It's almost impossible to get wrong, and it keeps you out of arguing about whether the want was reasonable.

Step 2: Name It

Naming means putting a simple word to the feeling.

"You're so disappointed." "You're really frustrated." "That made you mad."

This step does more than it seems. Siegel and Bryson call it "name it to tame it."⁵ There's research behind the idea, too. In one brain-imaging study, adults who put their feelings into words showed

5. Daniel J. Siegel and Tina Payne Bryson, *The Whole-Brain Child* (Delacorte Press, 2011).

less activity in the amygdala, a part of the brain that reacts strongly to threats.⁶ That study was done with adults, not children, so we can't claim the same result for a four-year-old. But it fits what many parents notice: a feeling that has a name often feels a little less huge.

Naming also teaches. Every time you say "You're frustrated," your child learns a word they'll eventually use themselves, instead of using their fists or feet.

Tips for naming:

- **Keep it simple.** Mad, sad, scared, frustrated, disappointed, worried, excited. You don't need fancy words.
- **Guess, don't announce.** If you're not sure, say "I wonder if you're feeling..." If you guess wrong, your child will often correct you. That's still a win: they just named their own feeling.
- **Match the size.** A huge storm deserves a strong word. "You're SO mad" lands better than a flat "You seem upset."

Step 3: Hold the Limit

This is the firm part. You say calmly what will and won't happen.

"I won't let you take her backpack." "The show is finished for today." "We're leaving the park now."

Notice three things about these sentences.

They're about what you will do. "I won't let you hit" works better than "Don't hit!" because it doesn't depend on your child choosing to obey in a moment when they can't. It tells them the adult will keep everyone safe.

6. Matthew D. Lieberman et al., "Putting Feelings Into Words: Affect Labeling Disrupts Amygdala Activity in Response to Affective Stimuli," *Psychological Science* 18, no. 5 (2007): 421–428.

They're calm and short. No lecture, no threat, no "how many times have I told you." Say it once, in a low voice, like a fact about the weather.

They don't change because of the storm. If screaming changes the limit, your child learns that screaming works, and you'll hear more of it. Kind but firm means the feeling is welcome and the limit still stands.

Not every moment needs a limit. If your child is sad and not doing anything unsafe or off-limits, skip step 3. Connect, name it, and offer comfort. That's enough.

Step 4: Offer a Way Out

A child in a meltdown is stuck. They want something they can't have, and they don't know what to do next. The last step hands them a door out.

There are three kinds of way out. Pick whichever fits.

A choice. Two options you're happy with. "Do you want to walk to the car or ride on my back?" "Do you want to turn off the TV, or should I?"

Comfort. Something to help their body settle. "Do you want a hug, or do you want me to sit next to you?" "Let's take a big dragon breath together."

A plan. Something to look forward to. "Let's write 'park' on the calendar for Saturday." "You can have the red one next time."

Choices work because they give your child a little bit of control back, and a child who feels in control has less reason to fight. Keep choices small, keep them to two, and only offer ones you're happy with either way.

Putting it together: a worked example

Let's build a script from scratch for a moment that happens in lots of homes: **turning off the tablet.**

The situation: Your five-year-old has been playing a game on the tablet. You said "five more minutes" five minutes ago. Now you're taking it, and he's clinging to it and yelling.

Start with the reset. Feet planted, one slow breath out, soft face, low voice.

Connect. What did he want? To keep playing. **"You really wanted to finish your game."**

Name it. What's the feeling? Probably frustration. **"It's so frustrating to stop in the middle."**

Hold the limit. What's non-negotiable? The tablet time is over. **"Tablet time is done for today. I'm going to put it on the shelf."**

Offer a way out. A choice works well here. **"Do you want to press the off button, or should I?"**

Here's the full script, all four steps together:

"You really wanted to finish your game. It's so frustrating to stop in the middle. Tablet time is done for today. Do you want to press the off button, or should I?"

That's about fifteen seconds of talking. Then, just like with the 3-Line Script, **stay close and stay quiet.** If he keeps yelling, you can calmly repeat the limit and the choice, word for word. Repeating the same calm words is more effective than finding new ones each time.

Why the usual phrases backfire

You may be wondering why this book avoids some phrases almost every parent uses. Here's the short version.

“Calm down!” A child who could calm down on command would already be calm. Hearing it can feel like being told off for having a feeling. *Instead, try:* the reset, then **“I’m right here. Let’s breathe together.”**

“Stop crying.” Crying is how young children release a big feeling. Asking them to stop often makes the feeling come out another way. *Instead, try:* **“It’s okay to cry. I’m staying with you.”**

“One... two... three...” Counting can get quick results, but it doesn’t teach anything about feelings, and some children learn to wait for “two and a half.” *Instead, try:* hold the limit and offer a choice.

Bribes (“If you stop crying, you can have a lollipop”). A bribe in the moment teaches that meltdowns can lead to treats. *Instead, try:* offer comfort now, and plan a treat for a calm moment later if you want to.

“You’re fine.” When a child is clearly not fine, this teaches them that their feelings don’t count. *Instead, try:* name what you see. **“That really hurt your feelings.”**

None of these phrases makes you a bad parent. They’re what almost everyone says when they’re tired. The point is to have something better ready.

After the storm: the talk that teaches

The Calm Words Formula gets you *through* the moment. But the real learning happens *afterward*, once your child’s upstairs brain is back online.

Wait until everyone is calm. That might be ten minutes later, or at bedtime, or the next morning. Then have a short, relaxed chat. Three questions are enough:

“What happened?” Let them tell it their way. Listen more than you talk.

“How did you feel?” Help them find the word if they’re stuck.
“Were you frustrated? Disappointed?”

“What could we do next time?” Make a plan together. **“Next time the game has to end, maybe we can set a timer so you know it’s coming.”**

Keep it short, warm and forward-looking. This isn’t the time for punishment or a replay of everything they did wrong. It’s practice for the next storm.

When you don’t remember the formula

Some days, you won’t remember four steps. That’s what the 3-Line Script is for. If your mind goes blank, fall back to it:

“I see you’re _____. I’m right here. I won’t let you _____.”

The 3-Line Script is really the Calm Words Formula in its shortest form. “I see you’re” covers Connect and Name it. “I won’t let you” covers Hold the limit. And “I’m right here” is the comfort that helps your child find the way out.

Your 5-Minute Action

Write your own script for your hardest moment.

Go back to the moment you circled in the Find Your Moment list, or the pattern you noticed in your meltdown tracker. Use the fill-in card below to build a four-sentence script for it. Then say it out loud, twice. Yes, out loud. Words you’ve said before come back much more easily in a crisis.

When that moment happens again, use your script. Chapters 4 to 9 have 30 ready-made scripts if your moment is there, but a script you wrote yourself, in your own words, is often the one you’ll remember best.

THE CALM WORDS FORMULA: FILL-IN CARD

The moment: _____

Connect: “You really wanted _____.”

Name it: “You’re so _____.”

Hold the limit: “I won’t let you _____.” or
“_____ is done for now.”

Offer a way out: “Do you want to _____ or
_____?”

After the storm: What happened? How did you feel? What
could we do next time?

You now have everything you need for the first minute of any meltdown: the reset, the 3-Line Script, and the Calm Words Formula. Part 2 puts them to work in 30 real moments. Find yours, and let’s start.

PART 2

The Playbook: 30 Moments, 30 Scripts

Don't read this part cover to cover. Find your moment, read the bold line, and go.

How to use a script card

Every moment in Part 2 has the same six parts, so you always know where to look.

- **What's going on:** one or two lines on what your child is feeling or needing.
- **Say this:** the script. This is the part to use in the moment.
- **If it gets bigger:** what to say and do if the storm grows.
- **Instead of / Try:** a common phrase that backfires, and a swap.
- **Age tweaks:** small changes for ages 2-3, 4-5 and 6-7.
- **Next time:** one idea to make the moment easier before it starts.

Every script is built on the Calm Words Formula from Chapter 3: Connect, Name it, Hold the limit, Offer a way out. And every script

works best after the 60-Second Reset. Feet, breathe out, soft face, low voice. Then speak.

If you only have ten seconds, read the **Say this** line and go.

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CHAPTER 4

“I Don’t Want To!”: Ending Everyday Battles Without a Fight

Noah is four. It’s 5:15 pm at the playground, and his mom has already said “time to go” three times. Now she’s holding his shoes, he’s at the top of the slide, and he’s yelling “NO! Five more minutes!”

She’s tired. Dinner isn’t made. And she knows what comes next: the chase, the carry, the screaming all the way to the car.

Most meltdowns don’t happen during big events. They happen in the small, ordinary moments of every single day. Leaving, stopping, getting dressed, hearing no, waiting. These moments come around again and again, which makes them the best place to start. Get these right and you’ll feel the difference by the end of the week.

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Moment 1: “Five more minutes!”

Leaving the park or a playdate

What’s going on: Your child is having fun, and leaving means the fun ends. Stopping something enjoyable is one of the hardest things for a young brain to do, especially with no warning.

Say this: "You're having so much fun. It's hard to leave fun things. Two more slides, then shoes. Do you want to do the last slide fast or slow?"

If it gets bigger: Say the limit once more, calmly. "It's time to go. I'm going to help you." Then help. Carry them if you need to, calmly and without a lecture. Use the 3-Line Script on the way to the car: "I see you're sad. I'm right here. I won't let you run away from me."

Instead of: "If you don't come now, we're never coming back." **Try:** "You can be sad and still come with me. We'll come back another day."

Age tweaks:

- **2-3:** Use fewer words and more action. "Bye-bye, slide!" and wave together. A snack in the car helps a lot.
- **4-5:** Give them a job. "Can you be the one who finds the car?"
- **6-7:** Let them set part of the plan. "Do you want two more slides or one more swing?"

Next time: Give a warning before it's time to go, and make it concrete. "Five more minutes" means little to a young child. "Three more slides, then we go" is something they can count.

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Moment 2: "But I'm not done!"

Turning off screens

What's going on: Shows and games are designed to be hard to stop. Your child isn't being difficult on purpose; they're being pulled away from something very absorbing, often in the middle.

Say this: "You really wanted to keep watching. It's so hard to stop in the middle. Screen time is done for today. Do you want to press off, or should I?"

If it gets bigger: Stay calm and follow through. “I’m going to turn it off now.” Turn it off, put the device out of sight, and stay close. “I see you’re really mad. I’m right here. I won’t let you throw the tablet.”

Instead of: “That’s it, no more screens for a week!” **Try:** “Screen time is done for today. You can have it again tomorrow after lunch.”

Age tweaks:

- 2–3: Stop at the end of a short episode, not in the middle. Say “All done!” and sign it with your hands.
- 4–5: Let them choose where to stop: “at the end of this episode or after this level?” Then hold it.
- 6–7: Agree on the rules together when everyone is calm, and write them down. In the moment, point to the rule: “What does our screen rule say?”

Next time: Use a visual timer your child can see. It moves the “bad guy” from you to the timer. “The timer says it’s done” is easier to accept than “Mom says.”

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Moment 3: “I’m not wearing that!”

Getting dressed

What’s going on: Clothes are one of the few things a young child can control, and sometimes the itchy tag, the wrong color or the tight sleeve really does bother them. Often it’s a mix of wanting control and real discomfort.

Say this: “You don’t like how that shirt feels. You really want to pick. We need to get dressed before breakfast. Do you want the red shirt or the blue one?”

If it gets bigger: Keep it boring and calm. “Clothes go on before we go out. I can help, or you can do it.” If you’re running late, it’s okay

to help them dress while they protest. Narrate kindly: **"Arm in. Other arm. All done. That was hard."**

Instead of: "You're wearing what I picked, end of story." **Try:** "You can choose between these two."

Age tweaks:

- **2-3:** Offer just two items, holding them up. Make it a game: "Can your arm find the sleeve?"
- **4-5:** Let them pick the outfit the night before and lay it out together.
- **6-7:** Give them the rule and let them run it. "It needs to be warm enough for outside. You choose the rest."

Next time: Choose clothes the night before, when nobody is rushed. If your child complains about the same textures again and again, take it seriously. Some children feel tags and seams much more than others.

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Moment 4: "I wanted the BLUE cup!"

The tiny thing that isn't tiny

What's going on: To you, it's a cup. To your child, it was a plan, and the plan fell apart. Small disappointments feel huge to young children, especially when they're hungry or tired.

Say this: "You wanted the blue cup. That's so disappointing. The blue cup is in the dishwasher. Do you want the green cup or the yellow one?"

If it gets bigger: Don't argue about whether it's a big deal. It is, to them. Stay close and let the feeling pass. **"I know. You really wanted blue. I'm right here."** Offer the cup again once they're calmer.

Instead of: "It's just a cup! Stop being silly." **Try:** "That's disappointing. Blue is your favorite."

Age tweaks:

- **2–3:** Say less. “Blue cup. You wanted blue.” Then offer a choice with your hands.
- **4–5:** Use a plan. “Blue cup is for dinner. Let’s put it on the counter so it’s ready.”
- **6–7:** Invite problem-solving. “Blue is dirty. What could we do?” Many six-year-olds come up with their own fix, like washing it.

Next time: Watch for patterns. If “tiny thing” meltdowns cluster around the same time of day, check HALT from Chapter 2. A snack before dinner prevents a lot of cup disasters.

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Moment 5: “Why can’t I have a cookie?”

Hearing no

What’s going on: Your child wants something, and you said no. This is often a tantrum, not a meltdown (Chapter 2): they’re protesting to change your mind. The feeling is real, and so is the hope that pushing will work.

Say this: “You really want a cookie. It’s hard to hear no. Cookies are for after dinner. Do you want an apple or some cheese now?”

If it gets bigger: This is the moment to hold steady. “I hear you. The answer is still no. It’s okay to be mad about it.” Don’t bargain, and don’t add new reasons. If you give in after the screaming starts, the screaming gets louder next time.

Instead of: “Fine, just one, if you’ll stop crying.” **Try:** “You can be mad. The answer is still no.”

Age tweaks:

- **2–3:** Move the cookie out of sight. Out of sight really does help at this age.
- **4–5:** Use “when... then...”: “When dinner is finished, then you can have a cookie.”

- **6–7:** Give a short reason once, then stop explaining. “Cookies are after dinner because dinner is for growing.” Repeating the reason turns it into a debate.

Next time: Say yes to something whenever you can. “Yes, you can have a cookie after dinner” lands better than “No cookies now,” even though they mean the same thing.

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Moment 6: “I can’t wait!”

Waiting in line, waiting for you

What’s going on: Waiting is hard work for a young brain. It takes the kind of self-control that’s still being built (Chapter 2). Boredom plus a long line equals trouble.

Say this: “Waiting is so hard. You’re tired of standing here. We have two more people, then it’s our turn. Do you want to hold my hand or hold the basket?”

If it gets bigger: Give their body something to do. “Let’s count the red things we can see.” “Can you jump five times, quietly?” If they’re melting down, step out of line if you can, use the 3-Line Script, and come back when they’re calmer.

Instead of: “Stop whining, we’ll be done soon.” **Try:** “Waiting is hard. Let’s play a game while we wait.”

Age tweaks:

- **2–3:** Keep waits short when you can, and bring something to hold or chew.
- **4–5:** Play “I spy,” count things, or make up a story together.
- **6–7:** Give them a real job: holding the list, finding the next item, counting the change.

Next time: Plan for waiting before it happens. Bring a small “waiting kit”: a snack, a tiny toy, a book. And when waiting at home

(“Just a minute!”), make it concrete: “When I finish this email, I’ll come play.”

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Your 5-Minute Action

Pick two daily transitions and use a warning plus a script for five days.

1. Choose the two moments from this chapter that happen most in your home. (Leaving somewhere and screens off are the most common.)
2. Before each one, give a concrete warning: “Three more slides.” “At the end of this episode.”
3. When the moment comes, use the **Say this** line.
4. At the end of five days, notice what changed. Even one shorter meltdown is progress.

Transitions get easier with repetition. The more predictable your words are, the less your child has to fight them.

CHAPTER 5

Hands Are Not for Hitting: Stopping Hitting, Biting and Throwing Calmly

Lily is three. Her mom said no to a second popsicle, and before anyone could blink, Lily smacked her mom's arm. Hard.

Her mom's first feeling wasn't calm. It was shock, then a flash of anger, then a wave of worry. *Is my child aggressive? Did I do something wrong? If I don't come down hard now, will she hit other kids at daycare?*

If your child hits, bites or throws things, you are not alone, and your child is not a bad kid. Young children have strong feelings, quick hands, and not many words yet. When a feeling gets too big, it often comes out through the body before it can come out through the mouth.

Your job isn't to punish that feeling away. It's to do two things, in this order:

1. Stop the hurting, calmly and right away.
2. Later, teach a safer way to let the mad out.

Block first, talk later

With hitting, biting and throwing, **safety always comes before words**. Don't stand three feet away saying "We don't hit" while the hitting continues. Move first.

- **Block.** Catch the hand, move your arm, step back, or gently hold their wrists.
- **Move.** Put space between your child and whoever they're hurting. Pick them up if you need to.
- **Say the limit once.** Short and calm. **"I won't let you hit."**

Then do the 60-Second Reset and use the rest of the script. The big conversation about kind hands comes later, when everyone is calm (the after-the-storm talk from Chapter 3).

A quiet, firm, *boring* response works better than a big reaction. Some children hit partly because it gets a huge reaction. When hitting gets the same calm block every time, it stops being interesting.

The "safe mad" list

Telling a child "don't hit" leaves a gap: *then what do I do with this mad feeling?* The answer is a **safe mad list**: a short list of things your child is allowed to do when they're angry. Mad is okay. Hurting is not.

Good things for a safe mad list:

- Stomp your feet hard
- Squeeze a pillow or a stress ball
- Roar like a lion, or yell into a pillow
- Push against a wall with both hands
- Rip up scrap paper
- Scribble hard on a "mad page"
- Ask for a tight hug

You'll build your own family list at the end of this chapter. Once you have it, the scripts below end with an invitation to use it.

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Moment 7: When they hit you

What's going on: Your child is flooded with a feeling (often anger or frustration), and it came out through their hands. Hitting a parent can happen because you're the person they feel safest falling apart with.

Say this: (*Block the hand first.*) **"I won't let you hit me. You're really mad. You can stomp your feet or squeeze this pillow. I'm right here."**

If it gets bigger: Keep blocking, and move out of reach if you need to. **"I'm going to step back so I don't get hurt. I'm still right here."** Stay close enough to be there, far enough to be safe. Once the storm passes, reconnect: **"That was a big mad. You're okay. I'm okay."**

Instead of: Hitting back, or "How do YOU like it?" **Try:** "I won't let you hurt me, and I won't hurt you."

Age tweaks:

- **2-3:** Use very few words: "No hitting. Stomp!" and show them how to stomp.
- **4-5:** Name the feeling and the swap: "You're so mad. Show me mad with your feet."
- **6-7:** Afterward, talk about repair. "When you hit me, it hurt. What could you do to help fix it?" A hug, a drawing, or a sorry works. Don't force the word "sorry" during the storm.

Next time: Look for the build-up. Some children tense up, get louder or clench their fists before they hit. When you see the signs, step in early: "I can see you're getting mad. Want to stomp it out?"

Moment 8: When they hit another child

What's going on: Another child took a toy, got in their space, or said something that stung. Your child didn't have the words or the patience, so their hand did the talking.

Say this: *(Separate the children first. Then go to the child who got hurt.)*

To the hurt child: **"Are you okay? That hurt. I'm here."** To your child: **"I won't let you hit. You were so mad he took the truck. Let's use words: 'Stop! That's mine!'"**

If it gets bigger: Take your child a few steps away to calm down, with you, not alone. **"Let's take a break over here until your body is calm. Then we'll go back."** Stay with them and use the 3-Line Script.

Instead of: "Say sorry right now!" **Try:** "Let's check if Sam is okay."

Once your child is calm, help them repair: bringing Sam a toy or asking "Are you okay?" teaches more than a forced "sorry."

Age tweaks:

- **2–3:** Stay very close during play so you can block early. Give them simple words to use: "Stop!" "Mine!" "Help!"
- **4–5:** Practice the words at home when everyone is calm. Role-play with stuffed animals: "Bear took Bunny's ball. What can Bunny say?"
- **6–7:** Talk through what happened afterward. "What did you want? What could you do next time?" Help them come up with their own plan.

Next time: Shorter playdates, more snacks, and staying close to children who are just learning to share. Many hitting moments happen when children are tired or have been together a long time.

Moment 9: When they bite

What’s going on: Biting is common in toddlers and usually fades as children learn more words.⁷ A child might bite out of frustration, excitement, teething, or to see what happens. It is upsetting, but in young toddlers it’s a normal stage, not a sign of a mean child.

Say this: (*Gently move your child away. Check the person who was bitten first.*) **“I won’t let you bite. Biting hurts. You’re so frustrated. You can bite this teether (or this apple). You can say ‘Stop!’”**

If it gets bigger: Keep them close and calm. **“Teeth are for food. I’ll keep everyone safe.”** Give their mouth something safe to do: a chewy snack, a cold teether, a drink of water.

Instead of: Biting them back “so they know how it feels.” **Try:** “Biting hurts. I won’t let you do it. Here’s something you can bite.”

Age tweaks:

- **2–3:** Keep it short and very calm. Big reactions can make biting *more* interesting. Offer something safe to chew.
- **4–5:** Biting usually fades as words grow, so at this age look closely for the trigger (Chapter 2’s HALT) and practice words for that exact situation.
- **6–7:** Treat it like hitting. If biting keeps happening at this age, it’s worth talking to your pediatrician (Chapter 10).

Next time: Notice when biting happens. Is it at daycare pickup? When tired? During rough play? Many parents find one clear pattern, and changing that situation stops most bites.

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7. Nemours KidsHealth, “Biting,” kidshealth.org/en/parents/stop-biting.html.

Moment 10: When toys start flying

Throwing things in anger

What's going on: Throwing is a fast, satisfying way to get a feeling out of the body. The trouble is that it breaks things and can hurt people.

Say this: “I won’t let you throw the blocks. You’re really angry. You can throw these soft socks into the basket, or stomp with me.”

If it gets bigger: Move the throwable things out of reach, calmly. “I’m going to put the blocks away until your body is calmer.” It’s not a punishment; it’s keeping everyone safe. Then use the 3-Line Script and stay close.

Instead of: “Pick that up RIGHT NOW!” **Try:** “I’ll keep the blocks safe for now. When you’re calm, we’ll clean up together.”

Age tweaks:

- 2–3: Throwing is also how toddlers explore. Offer a “yes” to throwing: soft balls or scarves into a basket. “Balls are for throwing. Blocks are for building.”
- 4–5: Clean up together once calm. It’s not a punishment; it’s showing them how to fix what happened.
- 6–7: Give them the repair job: “The tower got knocked over. What’s your plan to fix it?”

Next time: Keep a “throw basket” with a few soft things in it. When you see the mad building, point to it: “Need to throw? Use the throw basket.”

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When to get more help

Hitting, biting and throwing are common in young children. But talk to your pediatrician if the behavior is very frequent, is getting worse instead of better over several weeks, is causing real injuries,

or seems to come with no trigger at all. Chapter 10 covers this in more detail. Asking for help early is a smart move, not a failure.

Your 5-Minute Action

Make your family's "safe mad" list, together, when everyone is calm.

1. Pick a quiet time. Say: "Everybody gets mad sometimes. Let's make a list of safe things to do when we're mad."
2. Let your child choose three to five ideas from the list in this chapter, or invent their own.
3. Write or draw them on a piece of paper and stick it on the fridge.
4. Practice once, for fun: "Show me your best mad stomp!"
5. Next time a hit, bite or throw is coming, point to the list: "What's on your safe mad list?"

OUR SAFE MAD LIST

When I'm mad, I can:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____

Mad is okay. Hurting is not.

CHAPTER 6

Everyone's Staring: Handling Public Meltdowns With Confidence

Ella is five. She's in the checkout line with her dad, eye level with a wall of candy. He said no to the chocolate bar. Now Ella is lying on the floor of the supermarket, kicking and wailing, and the woman behind them in line is sighing loudly.

Her dad's face goes hot. He can feel every eye in the store. The thought in his head isn't *What does Ella need?* It's *What are these people thinking of me?*

That's what makes public meltdowns so hard. You aren't just handling your child's feelings. You're handling an audience, and your own embarrassment, at the same time. And embarrassment pushes parents toward the two worst options: giving in fast to make it stop, or getting harsh to show everyone you're in charge.

This chapter gives you a third option. It starts with one idea:

Your job in public is the same as your job at home. Keep your child safe, stay calm, hold the limit. The people watching don't change what your child needs. They only change how it *feels* to you.

Handling the audience

Before the scripts, here's how to deal with the people around you.

The audience matters less than it feels. Many of the people watching have probably been exactly where you are. And the ones who sigh loudly are people you'll likely never see again.

Turn your back to the crowd. Physically. Kneel down, face your child, and put the room behind you. It helps you focus, and it gives your child a little privacy too.

You don't owe anyone an explanation. If you want to say something, keep it short and friendly:

- To a stranger who stares: **"We're okay, thanks. Just a tough moment."**
- To someone offering unhelpful advice: **"Thanks. I've got this."**
- To someone who is kind: **"Thank you. That really helps."**

It's okay to leave. Abandoning a cart, leaving a restaurant, or walking out of a party is not a failure. Sometimes the kindest thing for everyone is to move the storm somewhere quieter. You can always come back.

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Moment 11: The checkout-lane candy standoff

What's going on: Candy placed at child height, a long wait, and a tired child at the end of a shopping trip. It's close to a perfect storm. This is usually a tantrum (wanting something), so holding the limit matters.

Say this: "You really want that candy. It's hard to see it and not get it. We're not buying candy today. Do you want to help me put the food on the belt, or hold the list?"

If it gets bigger: Kneel down, turn your back to the line, and stay calm. **"The answer is still no. It's okay to be mad. I'm right here."** If the screaming continues and you can manage it, keep paying calmly. If you can't, it's fine to step out of line with your child until they settle.

Instead of: “Fine, take it, just stop screaming.” **Try:** “You can be mad about it. The candy stays on the shelf.”

Age tweaks:

- **2–3:** Distraction works well at this age. Give them something to hold or look at: “Can you find something red on the belt?”
- **4–5:** Set the rule before you go in: “We’re buying food today, not treats.” Remind them once at the checkout.
- **6–7:** Offer a plan they can agree to. “Let’s write candy on the list for Saturday.”

Next time: Shop after a snack, not before. Talk about the rule in the car, before you go in. And if you can, pick a checkout lane without candy.

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Moment 12: Meltdown at a restaurant

What’s going on: Restaurants ask young children to sit still, be quiet, and wait, often while they’re hungry and it’s late in the day. That’s a lot of self-control for a small brain.

Say this: “It’s so hard to wait for food when you’re hungry. You’re really tired of sitting. Voices stay soft in restaurants. Do you want to color, or go for a quick walk with me?”

If it gets bigger: Take a short walk outside or to the restroom with your child. “Let’s go outside until your body feels calmer. Then we’ll go back to our table.” Stay with them, use the 3-Line Script, and come back when they’re ready. If they can’t settle, it’s okay to ask for the food to go.

Instead of: “Everyone is looking at you. You’re embarrassing me.” **Try:** “Let’s take a break outside together.”

Age tweaks:

- **2–3:** Keep restaurant trips short and early. Bring your own snack for the wait.

- **4–5:** Bring a small “waiting kit” (from Chapter 4): crayons, a small toy, a sticker book.
- **6–7:** Give them jobs: reading the menu with you, ordering for themselves, counting the tables.

Next time: Order your child’s food first, go at quieter times, and sit near the door so a break outside is easy.

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Moment 13: The playground scene

When leaving the park turns into a public battle

What’s going on: This is Moment 1 with an audience. Your child doesn’t want the fun to end, and other parents are watching you try to get your child off the climbing frame.

Say this: “You don’t want to leave. You love this playground. It’s time to go now. Do you want to climb down by yourself, or should I help you?”

If it gets bigger: Follow through calmly. Walk over, help them down, and carry them if you need to. “I’m going to help you now. You can cry. We’re going to the car.” Keep your voice low. The calmer you look, the less interesting it is for everyone watching, including your child.

Instead of: Chasing them around the playground, or yelling from across the park. **Try:** Walk over, get close, and speak quietly.

Age tweaks:

- **2–3:** Carry them if needed, gently and without a fight. Sing a “goodbye park” song on the way out.
- **4–5:** Use the same warning every time: “Three more slides, then shoes.”
- **6–7:** Agree on the leaving time before you arrive: “We’ll leave when the big hand is on the six.”

Next time: Park in a spot where you can reach the car easily, and bring a snack for the walk back. A snack in hand makes leaving much easier.

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Moment 14: Family gatherings

And Grandma's "In my day..."

What's going on: Parties and holidays are loud, busy and full of sugar, late nights and people your child sees rarely. It's a lot of stimulation. On top of that, relatives may have strong opinions about how you should handle it.

Say this (to your child): "There's so much going on today. Your body feels like it's too much. Let's find a quiet spot together for a few minutes. Do you want to bring your bear?"

Say this (to relatives): "Thanks. I know it looked different when you were raising kids. This is what's working for us." Or, more simply: "We've got this. We'll be back in a few minutes."

If it gets bigger: Take your child to a quiet room, a bedroom, the car, or outside. Sit with them, lower the lights if you can, and use the 3-Line Script. A child who is overwhelmed usually needs less noise, not more talking.

Instead of: "Stop embarrassing me in front of everyone." **Try:** "Let's take a break together. Big days are a lot."

Age tweaks:

- **2-3:** Keep their nap and meal times as close to normal as you can, even on party days.
- **4-5:** Before the party, tell them what will happen: who will be there, how long you'll stay, and where the quiet spot is.
- **6-7:** Give them a signal they can use when it's too much, like tugging your sleeve. Then honor it.

Next time: Arrive fed and rested, plan a quiet room ahead of time, and leave before your child falls apart, not after. A short, happy visit beats a long, disastrous one.

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Moment 15: The car-seat arch-and-scream

What's going on: Your child doesn't want to be buckled in. They may be tired, done with errands, or just want control. Car seats aren't optional, which makes this one of the clearest limits you'll ever hold.

Say this: "You don't want to go in your car seat. You wish you could stay out. The car doesn't move until you're buckled. Do you want to climb in yourself, or should I lift you?"

If it gets bigger: Stay calm and patient. "I'll wait until you're ready. The car doesn't go until everyone is safe." If you need to, gently place them in the seat and buckle them, talking calmly the whole time. If your child unbuckles or melts down while you're driving, don't turn around. When you can, pull over somewhere safe, then use the script.

Instead of: "Get in or we're leaving you here!" **Try:** "Car seats keep us safe. I'll help you."

Age tweaks:

- **2–3:** Make it playful: "Can you find the buckle?" Let them hold a small toy while you buckle.
- **4–5:** Let them do one part themselves, such as climbing in or doing the chest clip, while you check it.
- **6–7:** Give them a job for the ride: navigator, music chooser, window spotter.

Next time: Leave a few extra minutes so you're not rushing, and keep a small "car only" toy or book that appears only when they're buckled in.

Your 5-Minute Action

Plan your exit before the next outing.

Before your next trip to a store, restaurant or family event, take two minutes to plan:

1. **Where will we go if it gets too much?** The car, outside, a quiet room.
2. **What will I say to my child?** Pick the script from this chapter.
3. **What will I say to anyone watching?** “We’re okay, thanks.”
4. **What will I bring?** Snack, water, waiting kit.

Having a plan doesn’t stop every public meltdown. But it stops *you* from being caught off guard, and a calm parent is the best tool you have.

OUTING CHECKLIST

Before we go:

- Snack and water
- Waiting kit (crayons, small toy, book)
- Talked about the plan (“We’re buying food, not treats”)
- Know our quiet spot or exit
- Rested and fed, or keep it short

If it gets too much:

- Turn my back to the crowd
- 60-Second Reset
- Script from this chapter
- Leave if we need to. It’s okay.

CHAPTER 7

Out the Door and Into Bed: Mornings and Bedtimes Without the War

Jack is six. It's 7:50 am, school starts at 8:15, and he's lying on the hallway floor in one sock, building a Lego spaceship. His mom has asked him to put his shoes on four times. The fifth time, she yells. Jack cries. They both arrive late and grumpy.

Twelve hours later, it happens again in reverse. Now Jack won't stop. One more story, one more drink of water, one more question about sharks. His mom, who has been "on" since 6:30 am, finally snaps.

Mornings and bedtimes are hard for the same reason: **they're full of transitions, and they happen when everyone is short on time or energy.** In the morning, you're rushing. At night, you're exhausted. Your child feels both.

The good news is that these moments happen at the same time, in the same way, every day. That makes them the easiest ones to plan for. The secret weapon for both is a **routine**: the same steps, in the same order, every day, so your child knows what comes next without you having to push.

Why routines calm things down

When your child knows exactly what comes next, there's less to argue about. The routine becomes the boss, not you. "What's next

on the chart?” is a question. “Put your shoes on!” for the fifth time is a fight.

You’ll make a picture routine chart with your child at the end of this chapter. For now, here are the five moments where mornings and bedtimes most often fall apart.

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Moment 16: “I don’t want to get up!”

What’s going on: Your child is still tired, cozy, and not ready for the day to start. Some children wake slowly and feel grumpy for the first few minutes, much like adults.

Say this: “You’re so cozy. It’s hard to get out of a warm bed. It’s time to get up now. Do you want to hop out like a frog or roll out like a log?”

If it gets bigger: Keep it light and physical. Open the curtains, turn on a light, and give them a few minutes. “I’ll be back in two minutes, and then it’s time for feet on the floor.” Come back when you said you would, and help them up calmly.

Instead of: “Get up NOW, we’re going to be late!” **Try:** “Good morning. Two more minutes of snuggles, then feet on the floor.”

Age tweaks:

- **2–3:** A cuddle and a song usually works better than words. Carry them to breakfast if you need to.
- **4–5:** Make it a game: “Can you get to the kitchen before I finish counting to ten?”
- **6–7:** Try an alarm clock they can set themselves. Being woken by a clock often causes fewer fights than being woken by a parent.

Next time: Look at bedtime. A child who fights getting up is often a child who went to sleep too late. Moving bedtime earlier by 15 minutes can change the whole morning.

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Moment 17: Shoes, coat, teeth: the morning rush

What's going on: You're watching the clock. Your child isn't. Young children live in the moment, and "we're going to be late" doesn't mean much to them yet. Your stress rises, and they feel it without understanding it.

Say this: "You're busy building your spaceship. It's hard to stop. It's time for shoes. Do you want to put them on at the door or on the stairs?"

If it gets bigger: Get close and help. Rushing children with words rarely works, but helping with your hands does. "I'll put one shoe on, and you do the other." Stay calm even if you're late. Being five minutes late calmly is better than being on time after a screaming match.

Instead of: "Hurry up! Why are you always so slow?" **Try:** "What's next on the chart?"

Age tweaks:

- **2–3:** Do most of it for them, with them helping one small part. "You push the arm through."
- **4–5:** Race a timer or a song: "Can you get your shoes on before the song ends?"
- **6–7:** Let them run their own routine from the chart, and only step in when they're stuck.

Next time: Do as much as you can the night before: clothes laid out, bags packed, shoes by the door. And wake up 10 minutes earlier than you think you need. Most morning meltdowns are really time pressure meltdowns.

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Moment 18: “Just one more story!”

Bedtime stalling

What’s going on: Your child wants more time with you, more fun, or just to put off the dark and quiet. Stalling is often about connection: bedtime is when they have your full attention, and they don’t want it to end.

Say this: “You love story time. You wish it could go on and on. That was the last story for tonight. Do you want a big hug or a tiny squeeze before lights out?”

If it gets bigger: Stay kind and boring. “Story time is finished. I’ll see you in the morning.” If they call out, respond briefly and calmly each time, without starting a new conversation. “It’s sleep time. I love you.”

Instead of: “If you ask one more time, no stories tomorrow!” **Try:** “We’ll read the next chapter tomorrow night. I can’t wait.”

Age tweaks:

- 2–3: Keep the routine exactly the same every night. The same book, the same song, the same words.
- 4–5: Offer a “bedtime ticket”: one free trip out of bed (for water, a hug, the toilet). Once it’s used, it’s used.
- 6–7: Let them read quietly to themselves for a set time after lights out. It gives them some control, and it helps some children wind down.

Next time: Build the connection they’re asking for into the routine itself. Five minutes of one-on-one chat before lights out often cuts down on the stalling that comes after.

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Moment 19: “I’m not tired!”

What’s going on: An overtired child can look wired rather than sleepy. They may be running around, silly, or cranky, and completely sure they don’t need to sleep.

Say this: “Your body feels full of energy. It doesn’t feel like sleepy time to you. Bodies still need rest, even when they’re not tired. You can lie in bed and rest your body quietly. Do you want the night-light on or off?”

If it gets bigger: Don’t argue about whether they’re tired. Focus on what they need to do: “You don’t have to fall asleep. You do need to stay in bed and rest.” Dim the lights, turn off screens, keep your voice low and slow.

Instead of: “You ARE tired. Look at you!” **Try:** “You don’t have to sleep. You just need to rest your body.”

Age tweaks:

- **2–3:** Start the bedtime routine earlier. Toddlers who miss their window often get a second wind.
- **4–5:** Try a calm-down activity in bed: breathing slowly with a stuffed animal on their tummy, watching it rise and fall.
- **6–7:** Explain once, when they’re calm, why sleep matters for growing bodies and brains. Then let the routine do the work.

Next time: Stop screens well before bedtime and dim the lights in the house as bedtime gets close. A calm last hour makes “I’m not tired” much less common.

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Moment 20: “There’s a monster in my room”

Night-time fears

What’s going on: Many young children go through phases of being afraid of the dark, monsters or bad dreams, especially as their

imagination grows. The fear is real to them, even when the monster isn't.

Say this: “You’re scared. Feeling scared at night is really hard. I’m right here, and you’re safe. Do you want the night-light on, or your special bear to guard you?”

If it gets bigger: Stay close for a few minutes and keep your voice calm and low. “I’ll sit with you until your body feels calmer. You’re safe.” Avoid a long search for monsters, which can make the fear feel more real. A short check and a calm “all clear” is enough.

Instead of: “Don’t be silly, monsters aren’t real.” **Try:** “You feel scared. I’m here, and you’re safe.”

Age tweaks:

- **2–3:** A night-light, a favorite stuffed animal, and a short, predictable goodnight routine.
- **4–5:** Give them a “brave tool”: a flashlight they can keep by the bed, or a special blanket.
- **6–7:** Talk about fears during the day, when they’re calm. Draw the monster together and give it a silly name. Fears often shrink in daylight.

Next time: Keep scary shows and stories away from the hour before bed. If night fears are very frequent, get worse over time, or come with nightmares that seriously disrupt sleep for weeks, mention it to your pediatrician (Chapter 10).

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Your 5-Minute Action

Make a picture routine chart with your child.

1. Pick one routine to start with: morning or bedtime, whichever is harder in your home.
2. List the steps together, in order. Keep it to five or six steps.

3. Let your child draw a picture for each step, or cut pictures out of magazines, or take photos of them doing each step.
4. Stick the chart where the routine happens: by the front door, or next to the bed.
5. From now on, instead of giving orders, ask: “**What’s next on the chart?**”

Children follow a routine they helped make much more willingly than one handed to them.

OUR ROUTINE CHART

Morning / Bedtime (circle one)

1. _____ (draw it!)
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____
6. _____

When the chart is done, I can: _____

CHAPTER 8

“That’s Mine!”: Siblings, Sharing and Keeping the Peace

Rosie is six and Ben is three. Rosie built a castle out of blocks. Ben knocked it down. Rosie shoved Ben. Ben screamed. Both of them ran to their dad at the same time, both shouting “It’s not FAIR!”

Their dad had about two seconds to decide who was right. Ben started it, but Rosie pushed. Rosie is older and “should know better,” but Ben knocked down her castle on purpose. Whatever he decided, one child would feel it was unfair.

Here’s the relief: **you don’t have to be the judge.** Most of the time, deciding who started it makes things worse, because someone always loses. This chapter gives you a different job. Instead of judge, you become the **sportscaster**.

Be a sportscaster, not a judge

A sports commentator describes what’s happening without taking sides. You can do the same with sibling fights. Describe what you see, calmly and without blame, then hand the problem back to the children to solve, with your help.

- **Judge:** “Ben, you knocked it down on purpose, so you’re in trouble.”
- **Sportscaster:** “The castle got knocked down. Rosie, you’re really upset. Ben, you’re crying because Rosie pushed you. That’s two upset kids. Let’s figure this out.”

When you describe instead of judging, both children feel seen, nobody feels blamed, and you avoid getting stuck in the “who started it” trap. Safety still comes first: if anyone is being hurt, block and separate before you say anything (Chapter 5).

Sharing isn't automatic

Adults often expect young children to share instantly. But sharing means giving up something you want *right now*, which takes exactly the kind of self-control that's still being built (Chapter 2).

That's why this book uses **turn-taking** instead of forced sharing. With turn-taking, each child gets to finish their turn, and the next child knows their turn is coming. It's easier to wait when you know the wait will end.

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Moment 21: The toy grab

What's going on: One child has something the other wants, so they take it. Young children act on wanting before they think about the other person's feelings.

Say this: “You really want the truck. Ben is using it now. I won't let you grab it. You can ask, ‘Can I have a turn when you're done?’”

If it gets bigger: Hold the toy yourself for a moment if you need to. “I'm going to hold the truck until everyone is calm.” Then help both children: “Ben, you can finish your turn. Then it's Rosie's turn. I'll help you remember.”

Instead of: “Share with your brother right now!” **Try:** “When you're done with your turn, it's his turn.”

Age tweaks:

- **2–3:** Offer a swap: “Here's another truck you can use while you wait.” Toddlers accept a replacement more easily than a wait.

- **4–5:** Use a timer for turns: “When the timer beeps, it’s Rosie’s turn.”
- **6–7:** Let them negotiate: “You both want it. What’s your plan?” Step in only if the plan isn’t fair to both.

Next time: Before a playdate, put away a few very special toys that your child doesn’t have to share. It prevents fights over the things they care most about.

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Moment 22: “It’s not fair!”

What’s going on: Children watch closely for fairness, especially between siblings. Often “it’s not fair” really means “I’m worried I matter less.”

Say this: “It feels unfair to you. You wish you had one too. In our family, everyone gets what they need, even if it’s not always the same thing. Do you want to tell me more about what feels unfair?”

If it gets bigger: Don’t argue about whether it’s fair. Listen. “You feel like your sister got more. That’s a hard feeling.” Often a child who feels heard lets go of the complaint.

Instead of: “Life isn’t fair, get used to it.” **Try:** “It feels unfair. Tell me about it.”

Age tweaks:

- **2–3:** Keep it simple: “You want a cookie too. Here’s your cookie.”
- **4–5:** Use the language of turns: “Today was her turn to pick the park. Tomorrow is your turn.”
- **6–7:** Talk about the difference between equal and fair: “Your brother gets help with his shoes because he’s three. You get to stay up later because you’re six. That’s fair, even though it’s not the same.”

Next time: Spend a little one-on-one time with each child every day (see this chapter's action step). Many "not fair" complaints fade when each child feels they get their own share of you.

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Moment 23: When siblings hit each other

What's going on: Brothers and sisters live close together, share space and toys, and fight over both. Hitting between siblings is common, but it still needs a firm limit every time.

Say this: *(Separate them first. Check on the hurt child.)* **"I won't let you hit each other. You're both really mad. Let's take a break: you sit here, you sit there, until your bodies are calm. Then we'll talk."**

If it gets bigger: Keep them apart and stay calm. Use the sports-caster approach to describe what happened without blame. **"It looks like you both wanted the same seat, and then there was hitting."** Help each child calm down, and use the safe mad list (Chapter 5).

Instead of: "Who started it?" **Try:** "What happened? Let's hear from each of you."

Age tweaks:

- **2-3:** Stay very close when a toddler plays with an older sibling. Block early, and teach the older child to call you instead of hitting back.
- **4-5:** Practice words for sibling problems when everyone is calm: "Stop, I don't like that!" "I'm using this."
- **6-7:** Have them help make the plan: "What can we do so this doesn't happen again?" Write down their ideas.

Next time: Notice when sibling fights happen. Many happen when children are hungry, tired, or bored. A snack, a change of activity, or some time apart often prevents the next one.

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Moment 24: Jealous of the new baby

What's going on: A new baby changes everything for an older child. They may feel pushed aside, worried about losing your love, or just confused. Jealousy can show up as anger, clinginess, or acting “like a baby” again.

Say this: “It’s hard having a new baby in the house. Sometimes you wish it was just you and me. I love you so much, and that will never change. Do you want to read a book together, just us two?”

If it gets bigger: Take their feelings seriously, even when they say “I don’t like the baby.” **“You don’t like the baby right now. That’s a real feeling. I won’t let you hurt the baby. You can tell me when you feel mad.”** Then give them some of your attention, even a few minutes.

Instead of: “You should love your baby brother!” **Try:** “It’s okay to have mixed feelings about the baby.”

Age tweaks:

- **2–3:** Expect some going backward, like wanting a bottle or a pacifier again. Stay patient; it usually passes.
- **4–5:** Give them a “big kid” job with the baby, like choosing the baby’s socks or singing to the baby, if they want to.
- **6–7:** Tell them what makes them special: “You can do so many things the baby can’t. Want to stay up ten minutes later tonight and read with me?”

Next time: Schedule time alone with your older child, even ten minutes a day. Name it something special, and protect it. It reassures them more than any words can.

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Your 5-Minute Action

Give each child five minutes of one-on-one "special time" today.

1. Pick a time when you can give one child your full attention. Put your phone in another room, and save the chores and the other children for afterward.
2. Let your child choose the activity. Play what they want, the way they want.
3. Give it a name, like "special time" or "just us time," so they know it's theirs.
4. Try to do it every day, even if it's only five minutes.

Children who feel they get enough of you have less reason to fight their siblings for it.

CHAPTER 9

“I Hate You!”: Big Disappointments, Big Fears, Big Words

Owen is five. He was losing a board game to his grandpa, and when the last card went the wrong way, he swept the pieces onto the floor and shouted, “I hate this game! I hate YOU!”

His mom, watching from the kitchen, felt her stomach drop. *Did he really just say that?*

Words like “I hate you” hit hard. So do tears over a broken toy that seems tiny to us, or panic about a dog on the sidewalk. These moments are different from the battles in earlier chapters. There’s often no rule being broken and nothing to hold firm on. There’s just a child with a feeling too big to carry.

This chapter is about those feelings: disappointment, fear, and the big, hurtful words that come out when a child doesn’t have better ones yet. Your main job here isn’t to set a limit. It’s to **stay steady, name the feeling, and help your child carry it**, without rushing to fix it or taking the words personally.

Comfort before fixing

When a child is disappointed, most parents rush to make it better: glue the toy, promise a new one, find the bright side. It comes from love. But fixing too fast can send a message you don’t mean: *this feeling is a problem, so let’s get rid of it quickly.*

Try this order instead:

1. **Feel it with them.** "Oh no. Your tower fell."
2. **Let the feeling finish.** Stay close. Don't hurry it.
3. **Then fix, if it needs fixing.** "Do you want to build it again, or take a break?"

A child who learns that disappointment can be felt and survived is learning one of the most useful skills there is.

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Moment 25: Losing a game

What's going on: Young children want to win, and they haven't learned yet that losing is survivable. Losing feels like failing, and failing feels awful.

Say this: "You really wanted to win. Losing feels so bad. I won't let you throw the pieces. You can stomp it out, and then we can play again or do something else."

If it gets bigger: Pause the game. "Let's take a break from the game until your body is calm." Stay close and use the 3-Line Script. Come back to the game only when they're ready.

Instead of: "It's just a game. Stop being a sore loser." **Try:** "Losing is hard. Everyone feels that way sometimes."

Age tweaks:

- **2-3:** Choose games where everyone plays together, like building or matching, rather than games with a winner.
- **4-5:** Practice losing on purpose yourself, out loud: "Oh, I lost! I feel disappointed. I'll take a breath. Good game!"
- **6-7:** Talk afterward about being a good sport: "What can you say when you lose?" Practice "Good game" together.

Next time: Play games with a lot of luck and a little skill, where anyone can win, and narrate your own losses calmly. Children

learn more from watching you lose well than from being told how to lose.

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Moment 26: The broken toy (or broken tower)

What's going on: To your child, the toy wasn't just a toy. It was something they loved, built, or planned with. When it breaks, they may grieve it as a real loss.

Say this: "Oh no. Your tower fell down. You worked so hard on it. That's really sad. I'm right here."

If it gets bigger: Let them cry. Resist the urge to fix or replace right away. "It's okay to be sad about it. Take all the time you need." When they're calmer: "Do you want to build it again, or save that for tomorrow?"

Instead of: "Don't cry, we'll get you a new one." **Try:** "You really loved that. It's sad when things break."

Age tweaks:

- **2-3:** Hold them and name it simply: "Broken. So sad." Then offer comfort.
- **4-5:** Help them decide what to do next: fix it, throw it away, or keep the pieces.
- **6-7:** Talk about how to protect special things next time: "Where could we keep your towers safe from little brother?"

Next time: Give your child a safe place for special creations, like a shelf the younger siblings can't reach.

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Moment 27: When plans get cancelled

What's going on: Your child was looking forward to something: a playdate, the pool, a visit to Grandma. Now it's not happening.

Disappointment plus a change of plan is a hard mix for young children.

Say this: "You were so excited about the pool. Now we can't go. That's really disappointing. Let's put 'pool' on the calendar for another day. What should we do today instead?"

If it gets bigger: Stay with the feeling before moving to the plan. "You really wanted to go. It's okay to be upset. I'm right here." Only offer the alternative once they're a bit calmer.

Instead of: "Stop whining, it's not the end of the world." **Try:** "You were really looking forward to it. That's hard."

Age tweaks:

- **2-3:** Distract gently after the first wave of sadness: "Let's do water play in the bath instead!"
- **4-5:** Let them help choose a new plan from two options.
- **6-7:** Mark the new date on a calendar together, so the plan feels real.

Next time: When plans might change, say so ahead of time: "We're hoping to go to the pool, but if it rains, we'll go another day." A warning makes disappointment easier to handle.

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Moment 28: Tears at daycare drop-off

What's going on: Saying goodbye to a parent is hard, especially for young children. Your child may cry, cling, or beg you to stay. These tears are about missing you, not about daycare being bad.

Say this: "You don't want me to go. You'll miss me. I always come back. I'll pick you up after snack time. Give me a big hug, and then I'm going."

If it gets bigger: Keep the goodbye short and warm. Hand your child to a caregiver you trust, say goodbye clearly, and leave. "I love you. I'll be back after snack time." A long goodbye usually

makes leaving harder for both of you. It's fine to call the daycare later to check how they settled.

Instead of: Sneaking out while they aren't looking. **Try:** A clear, short goodbye, every time. Sneaking out can leave a child wondering when you'll disappear next.

Age tweaks:

- 2–3: Use the same goodbye ritual every day: a hug, a kiss, a wave at the window.
- 4–5: Give them something of yours to hold, like a photo or a scarf: “Keep this until I come back.”
- 6–7: Talk the night before about what they'll do at school or daycare tomorrow.

Next time: Practice short separations at home, and always come back when you said you would. Every time you return as promised, your child learns to trust the goodbye a little more.

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Moment 29: Scared of the dark, dogs or the doctor

What's going on: Fears are a normal part of growing up. As a child's imagination grows, so does their ability to picture scary things. The fear feels real to them, even when there's nothing dangerous.

Say this: “You feel scared of the dog. That's okay. I'm right here, and I'll keep you safe. Do you want to hold my hand, or stand behind me?”

If it gets bigger: Don't push them toward the thing they fear. Move to a place where they feel safe, and stay calm. “**We can stay over here. You're safe with me.**” Once they're calm, talk about it together.

Instead of: “Don't be a baby, it's just a dog.” **Try:** “You feel scared. That's okay. I'll help you.”

Age tweaks:

- **2–3:** Stay close and let them watch from a safe distance.
- **4–5:** Use picture books about the thing they fear. Some children feel braver after reading about it.
- **6–7:** Help them take small brave steps, like waving at a friendly dog from far away, then a little closer another day.

Next time: Talk about fears during calm times. Let your child ask questions and draw or play out the scary thing. For the doctor, role-play a check-up with a toy doctor kit. If a fear gets in the way of daily life for weeks, mention it to your pediatrician (Chapter 10).

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Moment 30: "I hate you!"

And "You're the worst mom ever!"

What's going on: "I hate you" is usually a child's way of saying "I'm so angry and I don't have a better word for it." It's not a real statement about your relationship. It's a feeling, spoken out loud, in the only words they could find.

Say this: "You're really, really mad at me. You wanted to keep playing and I said no. I love you even when you're mad at me."

If it gets bigger: Stay steady. Don't take the bait. "I can hear how mad you are. I'm not going anywhere." Later, when they're calm, you can talk about better words: "When you're that mad, you can say 'I'm SO mad at you!' That's okay to say."

Instead of: "That's a horrible thing to say. Go to your room!" **Try:** "You're really mad at me. I still love you."

Age tweaks:

- **2–3:** At this age it may come out as "No! Go away!" instead. Same response: stay calm and name the feeling.

- **4–5:** Offer better words: “You can say ‘I’m really mad at you.’” Practice it when calm.
- **6–7:** Talk afterward about how words can hurt: “When you said that, it hurt my feelings. What could you say next time?”

Next time: Model saying your own big feelings out loud in a safe way: “I’m really frustrated right now. I’m going to take a breath.” Children learn angry words from watching how adults handle anger.

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Your 5-Minute Action

Read one feelings picture book together this week.

1. Choose a picture book about emotions. Your local library will have plenty; ask the librarian for books about feelings, anger, or being scared.
2. Read it at a calm time, not during a meltdown.
3. As you read, ask: “How do you think she feels?” “Have you ever felt like that?”
4. Refer back to it later: “Remember the bear who was so mad? What did he do?”

Stories give children a safe way to practice feelings before the next storm arrives.

CHAPTER 10

When Nothing Works: What to Do When the Script Falls Flat

Priya is four. For a whole week, her mom did everything in this book. The 60-Second Reset. The 3-Line Script. Warnings before leaving the park. And on Friday, Priya still melted down over her socks, loudly, for twenty minutes.

Her mom sat on the stairs afterward and thought, *It's not working. Maybe it works for other kids, but not mine.*

If you've had a moment like that, this chapter is for you. Scripts are tools, not magic spells. Some days they seem to bounce right off. That doesn't mean you're doing it wrong, and it doesn't mean your child is broken. It usually means one of four things: the storm needs time, the words need to get smaller, something underneath needs attention, or it's time to ask for more help.

Let's look at each one.

A script can “fail” and still be working

Here's something that's easy to miss: **the goal isn't zero meltdowns**. The goal is shorter storms, quicker recovery, and a child who slowly learns to handle big feelings.

So when you judge whether things are working, don't ask “Did the meltdown stop?” Ask:

- Was it a little **shorter** than it used to be?
- Did my child **calm down faster** once it passed?

- Did it happen **less often** this week than last week?
- Did **I** stay calmer than I used to?

Any “yes” is progress. Change in young children is slow and uneven. There will be good weeks and bad weeks, and a bad day doesn’t erase the good ones.

This is where the meltdown tracker from Chapter 2 helps. Look back over a few weeks, not a few days. Many parents find that things are improving even when it doesn’t feel like it.

Say less

When a script doesn’t land, the most common reason is simple: **too many words**. A child in a storm can’t take in a paragraph, however kind it is.

If your script isn’t working, cut it down. Then cut it down again.

- **Full script:** “You really wanted to keep playing. It’s so hard to stop. It’s time to go now. Do you want to walk or ride on my back?”
- **Shorter:** “You wanted to stay. Time to go. Walk or ride?”
- **Shortest:** “So hard. I’m here.”

For children aged 2 to 3, the shortest version is often the best one. Pair it with calm action: pick them up, hold them, move somewhere quieter. Your body does most of the talking.

The same goes for older children in a very big storm. When they’re at the top of the wave, say almost nothing. Stay close, stay quiet, and save the words for later.

Check what’s underneath

Sometimes meltdowns increase because something else in your child’s life is hard. Before you decide the scripts aren’t working, look underneath.

Go back to HALT (Chapter 2). Is your child hungry, angry about something else, lonely, or tired more often than usual? A change in sleep or meals can change everything.

Look for big changes. A move, a new baby, a new school or day-care, a parent traveling, an illness, a family argument. Even happy changes can make children feel unsettled. It's normal for meltdowns to rise during a big change and settle again afterward.

Look at the pattern. Do meltdowns happen at the same time, in the same place, or with the same trigger? If so, you may be able to change the situation instead of handling the storm every time.

When it's too much: sensory overload

Some children feel noise, light, crowds, textures or busy places more strongly than others. When there's too much coming in, their system gets overloaded, and a meltdown can follow, often with no clear "reason."

Signs you might notice:

- Covering their ears or eyes
- Running away, hiding, or trying to get out of a busy space
- Melting down in loud or crowded places more than at home
- Being very bothered by clothing, tags, or certain food textures

What often helps:

- **Less input.** Move somewhere quieter and dimmer. Turn off music or screens.
- **Fewer words.** Say less, as above.
- **Space or pressure, whichever they like.** Some children want to be left alone; others calm down with a firm, snug hug or a heavy blanket. Follow your child's lead.
- **Planning ahead.** Shorter trips to busy places, a quiet break during parties, headphones for loud events if your child likes them.

Being sensitive to noise or textures isn't a diagnosis, and it isn't a problem to fix. It's useful information about what your child needs. If sensory struggles are getting in the way of daily life, like eating, dressing, sleeping or going out, mention it to your pediatrician.

Adjust for age

The scripts in this book work across ages 2 to 7, but how you use them changes as your child grows.

- **Ages 2–3:** Fewer words, more action. Short phrases, lots of comfort, and simple choices between two things you can hold up.
- **Ages 4–5:** More choices, more practice when calm. Role-play hard moments with toys, and let them help make the plan.
- **Ages 6–7:** More problem-solving together. Ask “What could we do next time?” and use their ideas, even if they're not perfect.

If a script feels too babyish or too complicated for your child, adjust it. You know your child better than any book.

When it's you who's struggling

Sometimes the script isn't working because *you* are running on empty. That's not a failure. It's a sign you need support too.

- **Look after the basics:** sleep, food, a few minutes to yourself.
- **Share the load:** if you have a partner or family member nearby, take turns with the hardest moments.
- **Lower the bar on hard days:** some days, getting everyone fed and to bed safely is enough.

And if you often feel overwhelmed, hopeless, or unable to cope, please talk to your own doctor. Parents' well-being matters too, and asking for help is a strong thing to do.

When to talk to your pediatrician

Most meltdowns in young children are a normal part of growing up. But some signs mean it's worth getting a professional opinion. The American Academy of Pediatrics suggests talking to your pediatrician if your child:⁸

- **Hurts themselves or others** during tantrums
- **Holds their breath and faints** during tantrums
- Has tantrums that **get worse after age 4**
- Seems to have **trouble expressing themselves with words** compared with other children their age

The CDC also advises talking with your child's doctor if your child **loses skills they once had**, isn't meeting developmental milestones, or if you have any other concerns.⁹

Throughout this book, we've also mentioned a few other situations worth bringing up with your pediatrician:

- Meltdowns that are **very frequent or very long** for your child's age, or that are **getting worse over several weeks** instead of better
- Meltdowns that seem to come with **no trigger at all**
- **Biting** that keeps happening at ages 6 to 7 (Chapter 5)
- **Fears or night fears** that get in the way of daily life or sleep for weeks (Chapters 7 and 9)
- **Sensory struggles** that make everyday things like eating, dressing or going out very hard (this chapter)

And one more: **your own gut**. If something feels wrong to you, that's reason enough to ask. You don't need to be sure. Pediatricians would much rather hear a question early than late.

8. American Academy of Pediatrics, "Temper Tantrums: What Parents Need to Know," Pediatric Patient Education.

9. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, "Learn the Signs. Act Early.," [cdc.gov/act-early](https://www.cdc.gov/act-early).

Making the most of the appointment

Bring your notes. The meltdown tracker from Chapter 2 is exactly the kind of information that helps a doctor understand what's happening: how often, how long, what sets it off, and what helps. Write down your biggest questions before you go, so you don't forget them in the moment.

Your 5-Minute Action

Notice which change makes the biggest difference.

For the next week, try one of the changes from this chapter:

1. **Say less:** cut your usual script down to its shortest version.
2. **Check underneath:** fix one HALT trigger, like an earlier bedtime or a snack before the hard moment.
3. **Less input:** move to a quieter spot at the first sign of a storm.

At the end of the week, write down which one helped most. That's your child's key, and it's worth more than any script in this book.

SAY LESS CARD

When the storm is at its biggest:

"So hard."

"I'm here."

"You're safe."

Then: Stay close. Stay quiet. Lower the noise. Wait.

Words come later.

PART 3

Fewer Storms Ahead

Parts 1 and 2 helped you get through meltdowns. Part 3 helps you have fewer of them.

CHAPTER 11

Feelings School: Teaching Calm When Everyone Is Calm

It's Sunday morning. Pancakes are on the table, nobody is tired, and nobody is crying. Nora, who is four, is happily drowning her pancake in syrup.

Her dad picks up a pancake and makes a sad face. "Uh-oh. This pancake is feeling... hmm. What do you think he's feeling?"

Nora giggles. "Grumpy! He's GRUMPY because you're going to eat him!"

They spend the next two minutes giving pancakes feelings. Happy pancake. Scared pancake. Frustrated pancake that can't find the syrup.

It looks like silliness. But Nora is doing something important. She's practicing feelings words, noticing faces, and learning that feelings have names, all at a time when her upstairs brain is fully switched on and ready to learn.

That's the big idea of this chapter: **the best time to teach calm is when everyone is already calm.** During a meltdown, your child can't learn much (Chapter 2). But in the easy moments, over breakfast, in the bath, on the drive to school, they can learn a lot. Think of it as Feelings School, in five-minute lessons.

Lesson 1: Words for feelings

A child who can say “I’m frustrated” has another choice besides throwing the puzzle. The more feelings words your child knows, the more ways they have to let a feeling out.

Here are some words to build up over time. Don’t try to teach them all at once. Pick one or two a week and use them often.

Ages 2–3: the basics Happy, sad, mad, scared, tired, hungry, silly.

Ages 4–5: adding more Frustrated, disappointed, worried, excited, proud, lonely, jealous, calm, grumpy, shy.

Ages 6–7: finer shades Nervous, embarrassed, annoyed, furious, hurt, confused, left out, overwhelmed, relieved, grateful.

How to teach them:

- **Name your own feelings out loud.** “I’m feeling frustrated because the car won’t start. I’m going to take a big breath.” Your child learns the word and a way to handle it.
- **Name feelings in books and shows.** “Look at the bear’s face. How do you think he feels?”
- **Name your child’s feelings when they’re mild.** Not just in big storms. “You look proud of that drawing!” “You seem a little nervous about the party.”

Lesson 2: Feelings games

Children learn best through play. These games take a few minutes and need nothing but you.

Feelings charades. Take turns acting out a feeling with your face and body, while the other person guesses. Mad stomping, sad slumping, excited jumping. Children love it when the grown-up does a very dramatic “grumpy.”

The inside weather report. Ask your child: “What’s the weather like inside you today?” Sunny means happy, cloudy means a bit sad, stormy means mad, foggy means confused or tired. Share

your own weather too. It gives children an easy way to talk about feelings that are hard to name.

Feelings faces. Draw simple faces together (happy, sad, mad, scared) and stick them on the fridge. Your child can point to the one that matches how they feel, even when words are hard to find.

What would you do? Tell a tiny story: “A little rabbit wanted the red crayon, but his friend had it. How do you think the rabbit felt? What could he do?” Let your child come up with ideas. It’s practice for their own hard moments.

Lesson 3: Kid-sized breathing

In Chapter 1, you learned to calm your own body with a slow breath out. Children can learn a version of this too, but “take a deep breath” is too abstract for most young children. Make it something they can see and do.

Blow out the candle. Hold up one finger like a birthday candle. Breathe in, then blow it out slowly. Try “blowing out” five candles, one finger at a time.

Smell the flower, blow out the candle. Pretend to hold a flower in one hand and a candle in the other. Breathe in slowly to smell the flower. Breathe out slowly to blow out the candle.

Dragon breath. Pretend to be a dragon. Breathe in slowly through the nose, then breathe out a long, slow “fire breath” through the mouth. Mad children often love this one, because it lets them be big and fierce while their breathing slows down. (This is the dragon breath from the comfort choices in Chapter 3.)

Belly buddy. Your child lies down with a stuffed animal on their tummy and watches it rise and fall as they breathe slowly. It’s a lovely one for bedtime (Chapter 7).

Practice when calm, use when upset. Practice these for fun at calm times, a few times a week. Then, when a storm starts, you

can say: “**Let’s do dragon breath together.**” A skill your child has practiced for fun is much easier to use when they’re upset.

Lesson 4: A calm-down corner

A calm-down corner is a cozy spot in your home where anyone can go when feelings get big. It’s not a punishment and not a time-out. It’s a place to calm down, and it works best when you go there *with* your child, especially at first.

You can set one up in about 20 minutes.

Choose the spot. A quiet corner of the living room, a nook in their bedroom, a tent, or even a big cardboard box with a blanket inside. Somewhere a little away from the action.

Make it cozy. A soft cushion or beanbag, a blanket, a favorite stuffed animal.

Add calming things. Pick a few from this list:

- Something to squeeze: a stress ball or a soft toy
- Something to look at: a glitter jar, picture books about feelings
- Something for their hands: play dough, a fidget toy, paper and crayons
- The feelings faces from Lesson 2
- Your family’s safe mad list (Chapter 5)

Introduce it at a calm time. “This is our calm-down corner. When you feel mad or sad or too-much, you can come here. I’ll come with you if you want.” Let them help set it up. A corner your child built is one they’ll actually want to use.

Use it yourself. When you’re stressed, say: “I’m feeling frustrated. I’m going to sit in the calm-down corner for a minute.” Children copy what they see.

Keep it positive. Never send a child to the calm-down corner as a punishment. If it becomes a place of shame, it stops working as a place of calm.

Lesson 5: Talk about the storm afterward

You already know the after-the-storm talk from Chapter 3: What happened? How did you feel? What could we do next time? This is Feelings School too. Every time you have this short, warm conversation after a meltdown, your child learns to understand their own storms a little better.

Over time, you may notice your child starting to do it on their own: “I was so mad because he took my car. Next time I’ll say stop.” That’s the goal of this whole book, arriving in small steps.

Your 5-Minute Action

Set up a calm-down corner this weekend.

Use the checklist below. Build it together with your child, and try one of the breathing games in it the same day, while everyone is calm.

CALM-DOWN CORNER CHECKLIST

The spot: _____

Cozy:

- Cushion, beanbag or pillow
- Soft blanket
- Favorite stuffed animal

Calming things (pick 3 or 4):

- Something to squeeze
- Glitter jar or calm picture book
- Play dough, fidget toy, or paper and crayons
- Feelings faces
- Our safe mad list

Practice together:

- Blow out the candle
- Smell the flower, blow out the candle
- Dragon breath
- Belly buddy

Remember: This is a place to calm down, not a punishment.
Grown-ups can use it too.

CHAPTER 12

I Yelled. Now What? The Repair Script

It had been a long day. Finn's mom had worked late, dinner was burned, and Finn, who is five, had spilled his milk for the second time. She heard herself shout, "WHAT is WRONG with you? Why can't you be CAREFUL for once?"

Finn's face crumpled. He went quiet and slid off his chair.

That night, after he was asleep, she sat on the edge of his bed and felt sick. *I know better. I've read the books. Why did I do that?*

If you've had a night like that, you're in very good company. Every parent loses it sometimes. You're tired, you're human, and you're doing one of the hardest jobs there is. This chapter isn't about never yelling again. It's about what you do *after*.

Why repair matters

A moment of yelling doesn't undo everything else you've given your child. But what happens next matters a lot.

When you come back to your child and make things right, you teach them several things at once:

- **Relationships can survive hard moments.** People who love each other can get upset and still be okay.
- **Everyone makes mistakes, including grown-ups.** Your child learns that mistakes can be fixed, which makes their own mistakes less scary.

- **How to apologize.** You can't teach a child to say sorry well by telling them to. You teach it by doing it.
- **Their feelings matter.** When you notice the hurt you caused and name it, you show your child that their feelings are important to you.

Some parents worry that apologizing makes them look weak. It's the opposite. A calm, honest apology shows your child what strength looks like: taking responsibility without making excuses.

The Repair Script

A good repair has three parts. You can say them in less than a minute.

1. Name what you did. "I yelled at you at dinner."

Be specific and honest. No need for a long speech.

2. Say it wasn't okay, without excuses. "That wasn't okay. It's not your fault that I yelled. I was tired and frustrated, and I didn't handle it well."

Notice the difference between explaining and excusing. "I was tired" explains. "I yelled because you spilled your milk" puts the blame on your child. Keep the responsibility with you.

3. Say what you'll do next time. "Next time I feel that frustrated, I'm going to take a big breath before I talk."

This part matters most. It shows your child that you're learning too, and it gives you a plan for yourself.

Here's the full script together:

"I yelled at you at dinner. That wasn't okay, and it's not your fault. I was tired and I didn't handle it well. Next time I feel that frustrated, I'm going to take a big breath first. I love you."

Then give them space to respond. Some children want a hug. Some want to tell you how it felt. Some just say “okay” and go back to playing. All of those are fine.

What to avoid in a repair

“I’m sorry, but you...” The word “but” cancels the apology. Keep the repair about what *you* did. If there’s something to talk about with your child’s behavior, do it separately, later.

Making it about your guilt. “I’m such a terrible mom, I’m so sorry, I always ruin everything.” Your child may end up comforting *you*, which puts a heavy job on small shoulders. Keep it short and steady.

Asking them to say it’s okay. “Do you forgive me?” puts pressure on your child. Let them respond however they want.

Waiting forever. You don’t need a perfect moment. Repair works best within the same day, once everyone is calm, but a repair the next morning is still worth doing.

Repair by age

- **Ages 2–3:** Keep it very short and physical. Get down to their level: “I yelled. I’m sorry. I love you.” Then a hug or a snuggle.
- **Ages 4–5:** Use the full three-part script. Ask one simple question: “How did it feel when I yelled?” Listen without defending yourself.
- **Ages 6–7:** You can talk a little more. Share what you’ll try next time and ask for their idea: “What could help us both when we’re frustrated?” Some children love having a family signal, like a hand on the heart, that means “let’s both take a breath.”

Repair when your child is the one who lost it

The same script works in reverse. After your child hits, yells or says something hurtful, you can help them repair too, once they're calm.

Don't force a quick "say sorry." Instead, guide them through the same three parts:

- **What happened?** "You threw the block, and it hit your sister."
- **How can we help?** "She's hurt. What could make her feel better?"
- **Next time?** "Next time you're that mad, what could you do?" (The safe mad list from Chapter 5 is perfect here.)

When children see you repair your own mistakes, they learn to repair theirs much more naturally.

Letting go of the guilt

After a hard moment, many parents replay it for hours. Guilt can be useful for a little while, because it tells you something mattered to you. But carrying it for days doesn't help you or your child.

Here's a simple way to put it down:

1. **Repair** with your child, using the script above.
2. **Learn one thing.** What set you off? Were you hungry, tired, rushed? What's one thing you could change? (HALT from Chapter 2 works for parents too.)
3. **Let it go.** Say to yourself what you'd say to a friend: "*That was a hard moment. I repaired it. I'm still a good parent.*"

You're not aiming to be a parent who never yells. You're aiming to be a parent who comes back and makes it right. That's something you can do every single time.

Your 5-Minute Action

Use the repair script once this week.

The next time you lose your temper, even a little, come back once everyone is calm and use the three parts:

1. Name what you did.
2. Say it wasn't okay, with no excuses.
3. Say what you'll do next time.

Afterward, notice how your child responds. You may be surprised how quickly your child moves on, and how close you feel afterward.

REPAIR SCRIPT CARD

1. "I _____ (what I did)."
2. "That wasn't okay, and it's not your fault."
3. "Next time, I'm going to _____."

Then: "I love you." Give them space to respond.

CHAPTER 13

Your 30-Day Calmer Home Plan

You've now got everything this book has to offer: the 60-Second Reset, the 3-Line Script, the Calm Words Formula, 30 scripts for real moments, and the tools to teach calm and repair mistakes.

That's a lot. And when there's a lot, it's easy to try everything at once for three days, feel overwhelmed, and go back to old habits.

So this chapter turns the whole book into a simple plan: **one small focus each week, for four weeks**. You don't need to be perfect. You just need to keep going. By the end of the month, the new words won't feel like a script anymore. They'll feel like you.

How the plan works

- **Each week has one focus.** Only one. Everything else can wait.
- **Each day has one small action**, usually five minutes or less.
- **Missed a day? Just carry on.** Don't restart, don't give up. The plan works even if you do it imperfectly.
- **Check in at the end of each week.** A few questions help you see your progress, even when it's slow.

Keep your meltdown tracker from Chapter 2 going through the month. At the end, you'll be able to compare Week 1 with Week 4.

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Week 1: Calm yourself first

Focus: the 60-Second Reset and the 3-Line Script (Chapter 1)

- **Day 1:** Practice the 60-Second Reset twice while calm: feet, breathe out, soft face, low voice.
- **Day 2:** Write the 3-Line Script where you'll see it: fridge, phone lock screen, car.
- **Day 3:** Use the reset once during a real hard moment, even a small one.
- **Day 4:** Use the 3-Line Script at the next meltdown. Then stay close and quiet.
- **Day 5:** Say one of your own feelings out loud, calmly: "I'm frustrated. I'm taking a breath."
- **Day 6:** Use the script again. Notice one thing that went a little better.
- **Day 7: Check-in.** Did I stay calmer at least once this week? Which step of the reset helps me most?

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Week 2: Your top three flashpoints

Focus: the scripts for the moments that happen most in your home (Chapters 3 to 9)

- **Day 8:** Look at your meltdown tracker. Pick the three moments that happen most.
- **Day 9:** Find those three moments in the Find Your Moment list. Read their **Say this** lines out loud, twice.
- **Day 10:** Use the script for flashpoint number one.
- **Day 11:** Use the script for flashpoint number two.
- **Day 12:** Use the script for flashpoint number three.
- **Day 13:** For any moment that isn't in the book, write your own script using the Calm Words Formula fill-in card (Chapter 3).

- **Day 14: Check-in.** Are any of the three flashpoints shorter or less frequent? Which script feels most natural?

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Week 3: Prevent the next storm

Focus: routines, warnings and the basics (Chapters 2, 4, 7 and 10)

- **Day 15:** Check HALT. Plan snacks before the hardest time of day.
- **Day 16:** Start giving concrete warnings before transitions: “Three more slides, then shoes.”
- **Day 17:** Make a picture routine chart for mornings or bedtime (Chapter 7).
- **Day 18:** Use the chart: “What’s next on the chart?” instead of giving orders.
- **Day 19:** Move bedtime 15 minutes earlier if mornings or evenings are rough.
- **Day 20:** Give each child five minutes of special time (Chapter 8).
- **Day 21: Check-in.** Which change helped most? Are there fewer meltdowns than in Week 1?

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Week 4: Teach calm and repair

Focus: Feelings School and repair (Chapters 11 and 12)

- **Day 22:** Teach one new feelings word and use it three times today.
- **Day 23:** Play a feelings game: charades or the inside weather report.
- **Day 24:** Practice dragon breath or blow out the candle together, for fun.
- **Day 25:** Set up a calm-down corner together.

- **Day 26:** Make your family's safe mad list if you haven't yet (Chapter 5).
- **Day 27:** If you lose your temper this week, use the repair script. If you don't, practice the after-the-storm talk after any meltdown.
- **Day 28:** Fill in your family's Calm-Down Plan (below) together and put it on the fridge.
- **Day 29:** Read one feelings picture book together.
- **Day 30: Final check-in.** Compare your meltdown tracker from Week 1 and Week 4.

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Your Day 30 check-in

Take ten minutes and answer honestly. There are no wrong answers.

1. Are meltdowns in our home **shorter, less frequent, or easier to recover from** than a month ago?
2. Do I stay calmer than I used to, at least some of the time?
3. Which **script or tool** do I use most without thinking?
4. Which moment is **still hard**? (Go back to its card in Part 2, or check Chapter 10.)
5. What's **one thing** I want to keep doing next month?

If you see even a small change, that's real progress. Children change slowly, and so do parents. Keep the tools that work, drop the ones that don't, and come back to this book whenever a new stage brings new storms.

And if, after a month of steady effort, meltdowns are getting worse or you're worried, look at the signs in Chapter 10 and talk to your pediatrician. Asking for help is part of the plan, not a failure of it.

OUR FAMILY'S CALM-DOWN PLAN

Put this on the fridge. Fill it in together.

When I feel big feelings, I can:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Our calm-down spot is: _____

My favorite calm breath is: Blow out the candle / Smell the flower / Dragon breath / Belly buddy (circle one)

Safe mad things I can do: _____

The grown-ups in our family will:

- Take a breath first
- Stay close and keep everyone safe
- Say "I see you're _____. I'm right here."
- Talk about it when everyone is calm

After a storm, we ask:

What happened? How did we feel? What can we do next time?

In our family, all feelings are okay. Hurting is not.

Thank You for Reading

You made it to the end, and that alone says a lot about how much you care. Now go do Day 1.

If this book helped you, would you take a moment to leave an honest review? Reviews help other parents decide whether this book is right for them, and every one gets read.

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The 30 Scripts Cheat Sheet

Short versions of every script in Part 2. Photocopy these pages or take a photo for your phone. Always start with the reset: feet, breathe out, soft face, low voice.

Everyday battles (Chapter 4)

1. **Leaving the park:** “It’s hard to leave fun things. Two more slides, then shoes.”
2. **Screens off:** “It’s so hard to stop. Screen time is done. You press off, or should I?”
3. **Getting dressed:** “You really want to pick. Red shirt or blue shirt?”
4. **The wrong cup:** “You wanted the blue cup. So disappointing. Green or yellow?”
5. **Hearing no:** “It’s hard to hear no. Cookies are after dinner. Apple or cheese?”
6. **Waiting:** “Waiting is so hard. Two more people. Hold my hand or the basket?”

Hitting, biting and throwing (Chapter 5) *Block first, talk later.*

7. **Hitting you:** “I won’t let you hit me. You’re really mad. Stomp or squeeze the pillow.”
8. **Hitting another child:** (*Hurt child first.*) “I won’t let you hit. Let’s use words: ‘Stop! That’s mine!’”
9. **Biting:** “I won’t let you bite. Biting hurts. You can bite this instead.”

10. **Throwing:** “I won’t let you throw the blocks. Soft socks in the basket, or stomp with me.”

Public meltdowns (Chapter 6) *Turn your back to the crowd.*

11. **Checkout candy:** “It’s hard to see it and not get it. No candy today. Help me with the belt?”
12. **Restaurant:** “Waiting for food is so hard. Soft voices here. Color, or a walk with me?”
13. **Playground:** “You love this playground. Time to go. Climb down, or should I help?”
14. **Family gatherings:** “So much going on today. Let’s find a quiet spot together.”
15. **Car seat:** “The car doesn’t move until you’re buckled. Climb in, or should I lift you?”

Mornings and bedtime (Chapter 7) *“What’s next on the chart?”*

16. **Getting up:** “It’s hard to leave a warm bed. Hop out like a frog or roll like a log?”
17. **Morning rush:** “It’s hard to stop. Time for shoes. At the door or on the stairs?”
18. **One more story:** “That was the last story. Big hug or tiny squeeze?”
19. **“I’m not tired”:** “You don’t have to sleep. Your body does need to rest. Light on or off?”
20. **Night fears:** “You’re scared. I’m right here, and you’re safe.”

Siblings and sharing (Chapter 8) *Sportscaster, not judge.*

21. **Toy grab:** “I won’t let you grab it. You can ask, ‘Can I have a turn when you’re done?’”
22. **“Not fair!”:** “It feels unfair. Tell me about it.”
23. **Siblings hitting:** “I won’t let you hit each other. You sit here, you sit there, until you’re calm.”

24. **New baby:** “It’s hard having a new baby. I love you so much, and that will never change.”

Big feelings (Chapter 9) *Comfort before fixing.*

25. **Losing a game:** “Losing feels so bad. Stomp it out, then play again or do something else.”

26. **Broken toy:** “Oh no. You worked so hard on it. That’s really sad. I’m right here.”

27. **Cancelled plans:** “That’s really disappointing. Let’s put it on the calendar.”

28. **Drop-off:** “You’ll miss me. I always come back. Big hug, and then I’m going.”

29. **Fears:** “You feel scared. That’s okay. I’m right here, and I’ll keep you safe.”

30. **“I hate you!”:** “You’re really mad at me. I love you even when you’re mad at me.”

When your mind goes blank: “I see you’re _____. I’m right here. I won’t let you _____.”

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Sources

The families in this book are illustrative composites. The research and guidance below support the factual statements in the chapters noted.

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What's Next

The Meltdown Playbook covers ages 2 to 7. But big feelings don't stop at seven. They just change shape: eye-rolls, "you can't make me," slammed doors.

The next book in the **Calm Words Parenting** series will bring the same script-first approach to the tween years. Follow Hannah (below) to hear the day it's released.

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About the Author

Hannah Rowe writes short, practical guides that give parents the exact words to use when things get hard. Her Calm Words Parenting series turns child-development research into scripts you can use in the middle of a meltdown, no parenting degree required.